



HUMAN RIGHT ABUSES IN NIGERIA

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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

At the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Define and explain the concept of human rights.
- Explain the concept of human right abuses.
- Identify common instances of human rights abuses in Nigeria.



WHAT DOES HUMAN RIGHTS STAND FOR?

Human rights are rights inherent to all human beings, regardless of race, sex, nationality, ethnicity, language, religion, or any other status.

Article 1 of the UN Declaration of Human Rights posits that

"All human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights. They are endowed with reason and conscience and should act towards one another in the spirit of brotherhood."

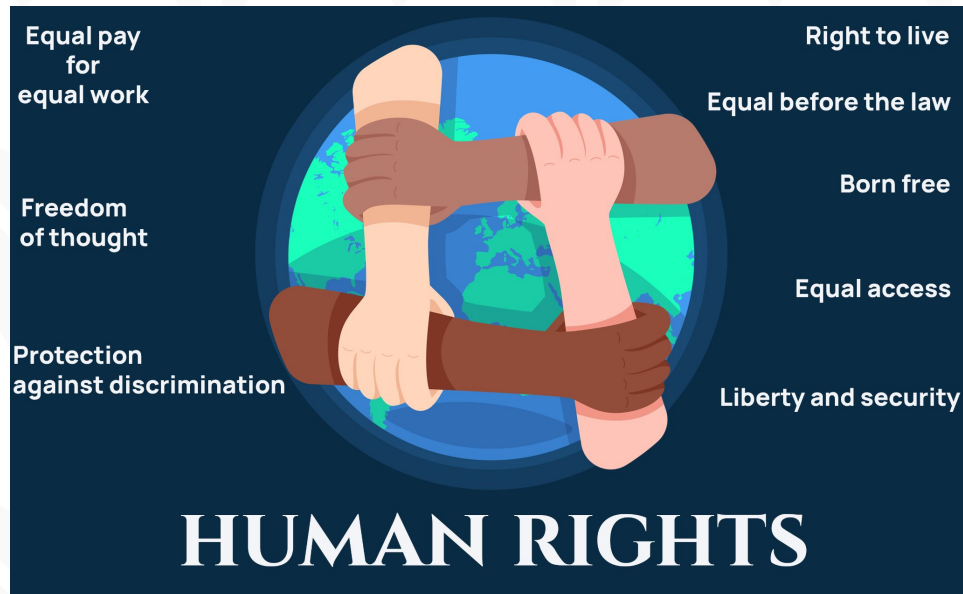


HUMAN RIGHTS



COMMON HUMAN RIGHTS

Human rights include the right to life and liberty, freedom from slavery and torture, freedom of opinion and expression, the right to work and education, and many more.





HUMAN RIGHTS IN NIGERIA

Human rights are contained in Chapter IV of the 1999 Constitution, Sections 33 to 46. The African Charter on Human and People's Rights also guarantees that rights are enforceable in Nigerian courts of law. These rights include:

- Freedom of religion
- Freedom of speech
- Right to education
- Right to freedom of movement
- Right to life





HUMAN RIGHT ABUSES

A human rights abuse is anything that harms someone's human rights. They include harm to people, communities, and the environment.

In Nigeria, the 1979 Constitution of Nigeria introduced Fundamental Objectives and Directive Principles of State Policy and Fundamental Human Rights, but there are still shortcomings and inhibitions in the 2009 Rules.

According to the National Human Rights Commission in Nigeria, it received 1,701,519 cases of rights violations in 2021. The figure was higher than the 1,287,280 complaints received in 2020.



COMMON HUMAN RIGHT ABUSES IN NIGERIA

Human rights abuses in Nigeria include the following:

- Extra-judicial killing
- Rape
- Freedom of expression
- Child marriage
- Domestic Violence



EXTRA-JUDICIAL KILLINGS

The Nigerian security forces, particularly the police and military, have been implicated in numerous cases of extrajudicial killings, torture, and excessive use of force.

The #EndSARS protests in October 2020 brought international attention to the issue of police brutality in Nigeria.

Examples of extra-judicial killings are law enforcement officials, non-state actors, death sentences, and deaths in custody due to the use of force or failure to protect the right to life.





RAPE

Rape is a serious human rights abuse that occurs worldwide, including in Nigeria. The Nigerian government and civil organisations are working to address the issue, but there are challenges such as social stigma, underreporting of cases, inadequate legal frameworks, a lack of access to justice, and limited support services for survivors.

There were about 367,000 women and gender-related issues in Nigeria in 2021.



SAY NO TO RAPE



ACTIVITY 1

Think of a time when you or someone you know experienced a situation where their human rights were not respected. How did it make you or them feel, and what actions were taken to address the issue?



FREEDOM OF EXPRESSION

The Nigerian government has been criticised for restricting freedom of speech and press, including freedom of press and media, including online media. Critics reported being subjected to threats, intimidation, arrest, detention, and sometimes violence.

Security services detained and harassed journalists, sometimes for reporting on sensitive topics such as political corruption and security.

The government controlled much of the electronic media through the National Broadcasting Commission (NBC), which is responsible for monitoring and regulating broadcast media.

The government used regulatory oversight to restrict press freedom, notably by clamping down on television and radio stations.





CHILD MARRIAGE

Child marriage is a discriminatory practise affecting mostly girls and is prohibited under international law. It is a violation of international human rights law if a State fails to establish a minimum age of marriage, enforce it, provide for and enforce the same minimum age of marriage for boys and girls, act with due diligence to prevent it, or involve public officials in it.

43% of girls in Nigeria are married before their 18th birthday, and 16% are married before the age of 15 (Aliogo, 2023).



#CHILD NOT BRIDE





DOMESTIC VIOLENCE

Domestic violence is a human rights abuse that occurs in Nigeria and other countries.

The Violence Against Persons (Prohibition) Act was signed into law in 2015, criminalising various forms of abuse and providing mechanisms for reporting, prosecution, and support services for survivors.

However, challenges remain in effectively addressing domestic violence in Nigeria, such as underreporting due to social stigma, inadequate enforcement of laws, limited awareness and education, and the need for more accessible support services.



SAY NO TO ABUSE



ACTIVITY 2

Can you identify any cultural practises or traditions that might clash with universal human rights principles? How can societies address these conflicts while respecting cultural diversity?



CONCLUSION

Finally, a nation's attitudes towards human rights are indicators of the values that its political and other leaders have espoused regarding human life. Human rights are not validated by the number of international treaties that countries and their governments have signed.

The international documents are just standards for the additional safeguards individuals demand from the state. As a result, every government agency has to enforce the norms established by the Constitution. Penalties should likewise be imposed regardless of socioeconomic class.



HUMAN RIGHTS





SUMMARY

In this lesson, we have:

- Defined and explained the concept of human rights.
- Explained the concept of human right abuses.
- Identified common instances of human rights abuses in Nigeria.



REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

J. A. Dada, Human Rights Protection in Nigeria: The Past, the Present and Goals for Role Actors for the Future, *Journal of Law, Policy and Globalisation*, vol 14 (2013).

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THANK YOU